CONNECT DAILY

Friday 23 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Quiet 24 hours nationally - the one notable move is a leadership change at the top of the DfE, not a policy announcement.
- Simon Ridley has been appointed the department's new Permanent Secretary, replacing Susan Acland-Hood, who is leaving for a role outside government.
- Today is the last working day before Sheffield schools break for autumn half term (26-30 October).

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

27 Oct 2026 — South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority Board meets.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

NATIONAL POLICY & DFE

- **New Permanent Secretary named at the Department for Education.** Simon Ridley - currently Second Permanent Secretary at the Home Office - has been appointed the DfE's new top civil servant, succeeding Susan Acland-Hood. Education Secretary Lucy Powell welcomed the appointment; it's an administrative change rather than a policy shift, but worth knowing given how much DfE direction runs through this role. (GOV.UK)

JARGON-BUSTER · PERMANENT SECRETARY

Today's top story is about the DfE's new Permanent Secretary - a role that shapes education policy long after ministers move on.

The Permanent Secretary is the most senior civil servant in a government department, running it day-to-day and advising ministers. Unlike the Education Secretary (currently Lucy Powell), a political appointee, the Permanent Secretary stays in post across changes of government and minister.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report

Source	Type	What we track
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.